



Roots first: For all his T20 fame, Tilak Varma still treats domestic cricket as sacred ground — the arena that keeps his game honest and evolving.

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innings sharpening the sense that his rise was not so much sudden as it was destined.

Filling big shoes

Tilak's emergence coincides with the retirement of two giants — Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli. "They're legends and inspirational figures. I'd like to be Tilak Varma in my own right.

"I do dream of finishing with most ICC trophies. If you remember, I started playing after the 2011 World Cup, and my dream is to win a World

Cup for India," he said.

Asked if he feels pressure to fill the void, Tilak replied, "I haven't thought about that. My aim is to do well in every game. They are legends, and replacing them is impossible. But I'll always give more than 100 per cent."

Influences and gratitude

Ahead of his first season with Mumbai Indians, then captain Rohit had quickly recognised Tilak's rare blend of technique and temperament, convinced the then 19-year-old had the makings of an all-format India player. Tilak carried that promise into his maiden IPL season, standing out as a lone bright spot, with 397 runs in 14 innings at 131, even as Mumbai endured a forgettable campaign.

"What I admire most about Rohit

bhai is his discipline on and off the field.

"Being a complete family man shows how grounded he is despite all his achievements. I'd love to follow that example," Tilak said.

He also credited his parents. "I feel privileged to get the support they've given me despite all their hardships. It's just the beginning, and hopefully, with God's grace, it will be a wonderful journey."

Cricket, as ever, will test not just his range but his resolve — whether he can sustain that discipline born of a 60-kilometre commute and a coach's quiet faith.

The next T20 World Cup, to be co-hosted by defending champion India and Sri Lanka, will arrive soon enough. Tilak is ready for the challenge.